

Child Selective Eating Guide — Action Checklist

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ASSESS CURRENT FOOD BASELINE

- ☐ **Create a complete food inventory by listing every food your child reliably eats, being specific about brands and preparations like 'chicken nuggets' vs 'chicken in any form':** Create a complete food inventory by listing every food your child reliably eats, being specific about brands and preparations like 'chicken nuggets' vs 'chicken in any form'.
- ☐ **Categorize each food in your inventory as safe (willingly eaten), maybe (sometimes accepted), or never (consistently refused) to map your child's current diet profile:** Categorize each food in your inventory as safe (willingly eaten), maybe (sometimes accepted), or never (consistently refused) to map your child's current diet profile.
- ☐ **Analyze your food inventory for patterns in texture, color, brand, temperature, and processing level to understand what drives your child's food preferences:** Analyze your food inventory for patterns in texture, color, brand, temperature, and processing level to understand what drives your child's food preferences.
- ☐ **Determine where your child falls on the selective eating spectrum:** typical picky eating (15-30 foods), significant selective eating (under 15 foods), or severe ARFID-risk (under 10 foods).

MAP SENSORY FOOD TRIGGERS

- ☐ **Watch for texture sensitivities like gagging on smooth foods or refusing mushy items to identify which food textures trigger genuine discomfort rather than defiance:** Watch for texture sensitivities like gagging on smooth foods or refusing mushy items to identify which food textures trigger genuine discomfort rather than defiance.
- ☐ **Observe whether your child rejects foods based on visual appearance, such as refusing all green foods regardless of taste or avoiding certain colors entirely:** Observe whether your child rejects foods based on visual appearance, such as refusing all green foods regardless of taste or avoiding certain colors entirely.

- ☐ **Track your child's temperature preferences by noting whether they accept foods only when warm, cold, or at room temperature to expand their diet systematically.:** Track your child's temperature preferences by noting whether they accept foods only when warm, cold, or at room temperature to expand their diet systematically.
- ☐ **Document smell sensitivities by noting which strong-smelling foods like fish, eggs, or cruciferous vegetables cause genuine aversive reactions in your child.:** Document smell sensitivities by noting which strong-smelling foods like fish, eggs, or cruciferous vegetables cause genuine aversive reactions in your child.

RECOGNIZE MEDICAL WARNING SIGNS

- ☐ **Monitor your child's growth curve at pediatrician visits to identify if their growth has flattened or if they've lost weight, which may indicate nutritional concerns.:** Monitor your child's growth curve at pediatrician visits to identify if their growth has flattened or if they've lost weight, which may indicate nutritional concerns.
- ☐ **Request blood work from your pediatrician to check for nutritional deficiencies, particularly iron, which is commonly low in children with restricted diets.:** Request blood work from your pediatrician to check for nutritional deficiencies, particularly iron, which is commonly low in children with restricted diets.
- ☐ **Watch for extreme anxiety around food such as panic, gagging, or vomiting at the sight of new foods, which may require professional feeding therapy support.:** Watch for extreme anxiety around food such as panic, gagging, or vomiting at the sight of new foods, which may require professional feeding therapy support.
- ☐ **Recognize when selective eating is causing significant family conflict or parental depression and seek professional support rather than struggling alone.:** Recognize when selective eating is causing significant family conflict or parental depression and seek professional support rather than struggling alone.